BUDAPEST, HUNGARY

Museum of Fine Arts: Masterpieces

Twenty paintings in which a task or a gesture gives the subject its structure.



A man trims a feather before writing. Diners pour and receive a drink. Mourners support a dead body. These actions belong to different genres, but each makes a relation visible through hands, objects and weight. Beginning with what people do can make a religious or historical painting less remote without reducing its subject to everyday life.

The selection also includes pictures where attention disperses through a crowd or gives way to landscape. Bruegel's sermon must be found within its audience; Pissarro's field allows small figures to remain part of the terrain. The aim is to follow where an action concentrates the picture and where the wider setting resists that concentration.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/fine-arts-budapest

The selection · 20

1. Saint Andrew
   Francisco de Zurbarán · 1631
2. Cutting a Quill
   Adriaen van Ostade · c.1660 - c. 1670
3. Jeanne Duval Reclining: Lady with a Fan
   Édouard Manet · 1862
4. La Varenne de Saint-Hilaire
   Camille Pissarro · 1863
5. Lamentation of Christ
   Maarten van Heemskerck · c. 1543
6. Portrait of a Young Man, Traditionally Identified as Antonio Broccardo
   Giorgione · 1500
7. Salome
   Lucas Cranach the Elder · c. 1530
8. The Annunciation to Joachim
   Lucas Cranach the Elder · 1518
9. The Lunch
   Diego Velázquez · 1620
10. The Martyrdom of Saints Placidus and Flavia
    Francesco Solimena · 1697 - 1708
11. The Sermon of Saint John the Baptist
    Pieter Bruegel the Elder · 1566
12. Venus, Cupid and Jealousy
    Bronzino · c. 1549
13. The Holy Family with Saint Anne
    El Greco · c. 1595
14. The Naval Battle of Lissa
    Konstantinos Volanakis · 1869
15. Self-Portrait
    Christian Seybold · 1760–1769
16. Thalia
    Michele Pannonio · 1456–1457
17. Horse Frightened by a Storm
    Eugène Delacroix · 1824
18. Jael and Sisera
    Artemisia Gentileschi · 1620
19. Paris Interior
    Mihály Munkácsy · 1877
20. Portrait of Petrus Egidius de Morrion
    Jan Lievens · 1637

01 / 20

Saint Andrew

Francisco de Zurbarán

1631 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Fine Arts



Francisco de Zurbarán. Apostle St. Andrew. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/francisco-de-zurbaran/apostle-st-andrew-1631 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The open book gives the apostle an activity rather than leaving him to stand as a collection of identifying signs. Strong light connects hands and face above the substantial ochre robe. Zurbarán makes sacred authority physically present through cloth, posture and reading. The body is available for close attention before a fuller account of the saint's role is supplied.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Cutting a Quill

Adriaen van Ostade

c.1660 - c. 1670 · Oil on wood · Museum of Fine Arts



Adriaen van Ostade. Cutting the Feather. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/adriaen-van-ostade/cutting-the-feather · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Writing has not started. The man prepares the feather, concentrating his hands and gaze on a small practical task. Van Ostade gives this preliminary labour a picture of its own. Uneven light narrows the room around the occupied fingers, keeping manual preparation visible instead of allowing the eventual written words to claim all the importance.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Jeanne Duval Reclining: Lady with a Fan

Édouard Manet

1862 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Fine Arts



Édouard Manet. Jeanne Duval, Baudelaire's Mistress, Reclining (Lady with a Fan). WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/edouard-manet/portrait-of-jeanne-duval-1862 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The white dress claims so much space that the portrait's proportions must be read through clothing. The dark head and small exposed shoe interrupt that expanse, while curtains crowd the background. Manet does not distribute emphasis evenly around a central face. Fabric becomes a major part of how the sitter occupies the picture.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

La Varenne de Saint-Hilaire

Camille Pissarro

1863 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Fine Arts



La Varenne de St. Hilaire. WikiArt; Camille Pissarro. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Small figures cross the field without providing one dominant incident. Pissarro gives broad areas of ground and sky their own intervals, with trees and buildings marking the transition between them. The people make the landscape inhabited but do not exhaust its interest. Attention can follow their movement or remain with the larger distribution of space.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Lamentation of Christ

Maarten van Heemskerck

c. 1543 · Oil on panel · Museum of Fine Arts



Maarten van Heemskerck. Lamentation of Christ. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/maerten-van-heemskerck/lamentation-of-christ · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The pale muscular body requires support from several hands and arms. Heemskerck makes the mourners' grief inseparable from the practical difficulty of handling the dead. Their compressed positions leave little distance between feeling and action. The group is connected by weight, not simply by a sequence of sorrowful faces directed at the same subject.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Portrait of a Young Man, Traditionally Identified as Antonio Broccardo

Giorgione

1500 · Oil on panel · Museum of Fine Arts



Portrait of a Youth (Antonio Broccardo). WikiArt; Giorgione. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The spread hand and slightly averted face make the sitter's attention difficult to name. Small objects on the ledge add information without resolving that inward turn. Giorgione gives a precise encounter with a painted person, but precision of likeness does not guarantee certainty of identity. The traditional name should retain its qualification wherever the portrait is reproduced.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Salome

Lucas Cranach the Elder

c. 1530 · Oil on wood · Museum of Fine Arts



Lucas Cranach the Elder. Salome. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/lucas-cranach-the-elder/salome · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Jewellery and refined clothing share the narrow field with a severed head. Cranach keeps the platter calmly presented, making elegance and violence impossible to separate into different moments of the story. The disturbing outcome is held within the same portrait-like arrangement as the young woman's pale skin. Decorative detail cannot be considered innocent of its immediate company.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

The Annunciation to Joachim

Lucas Cranach the Elder

1518 · Oil on panel · Museum of Fine Arts



Lucas Cranach the Elder. The Annunciation to Joachim. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/lucas-cranach-the-elder/the-annunciation-to-joachim-1518 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

An angel's descent meets the kneeling man's upward attention across a marked difference in height. Sheep and rocky ground maintain the pastoral setting around the encounter. Cranach allows the miraculous message to enter a world with ordinary continuities. Directed gestures connect the two figures without requiring earth and sky to become one undifferentiated space.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

The Lunch

Diego Velázquez

1620 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Fine Arts



Diego Velázquez. The Lunch. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/diego-velazquez/the-lunch-1620 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The objects on the cloth belong to actions: pouring, receiving, reaching and eating. Velázquez connects the men through their use of the table rather than a uniform pose. Bread, vessels and fruit therefore remain part of the company. The still life cannot be separated cleanly from the figures without losing the practical relationships that organise the meal.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

The Martyrdom of Saints Placidus and Flavia

Francesco Solimena

1697 - 1708 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Fine Arts



Francesco Solimena. The Martyrdom of Sts Placidus and Flavia. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/francesco-solimena/the-martyrdom-of-sts-placidus-and-flavia-1708 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Kneeling bodies and armed figures establish several centres of action beneath the airborne group. Solimena uses bright cloth to keep those centres distinguishable within the wide scene. Earthly violence and heavenly response operate at different heights. Reading the painting requires moving between them rather than expecting one gesture to contain the whole subject.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

The Sermon of Saint John the Baptist

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

1566 · Oil on panel · Museum of Fine Arts



The Sermon of St. John the Baptist. WikiArt; Pieter Bruegel the Elder. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The audience occupies more of the picture than the preacher. Bruegel embeds John inside a dense gathering whose turns and positions offer several ways of attending to the event. The sermon must be located rather than simply received from a dominating central figure. Public speech appears through the people assembled around it, with their varied proximity and response.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

Venus, Cupid and Jealousy

Bronzino

c. 1549 · Oil on panel · Museum of Fine Arts



Bronzino. Venus, Cupid and Jealousy. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/agnolo-bronzino/venus-cupid-and-envy · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Smooth bodies invite close looking, while their twisting relations make the group difficult to disentangle. Bronzino places gestures, flowers and darker forms within a shallow crowded space. The allegorical title supplies a starting point, not a complete key. Affection and desire are made complicated through the ways the figures overlap and reach across one another.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

The Holy Family with Saint Anne

El Greco

c. 1595 · Museum of Fine Arts



El Greco. Holy Family with Saint Anne. Image credit: El Greco / After El Greco. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Long fingers reach around the child, giving the close group physical connections despite its elongated proportions. El Greco's intense cloth colours distinguish bodies without separating their shared attention. The turbulent sky does not turn the gathering into ordinary domestic space. Intimacy remains clear through contact even when the figures depart from everyday anatomical measure.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 50.755

14 / 20

The Naval Battle of Lissa

Konstantinos Volanakis

1869 · Museum of Fine Arts



Konstantinos Volanakis. Naval battle at Lissa. Image credit: Konstantinos Volanakis. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Smoke and tilted masts obstruct an overall account of the fighting. From the low viewpoint, small boats and wreckage make the vulnerability beneath the warships visible. Volanakis does not provide the detached clarity of a battle plan. The immense vessels are encountered among their immediate consequences, where structures and bodies share dangerous water.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Self-Portrait

Christian Seybold

1760–1769 · Museum of Fine Arts



Christian Seybold. Self-Portrait. Image credit: Christian Seybold. Wikimedia Commons. CC BY-SA 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC BY-SA 3.0

An open white shirt and loose head covering frame the older face without adding a ceremonial setting. Seybold gives wrinkles and small changes of light particular attention. Age is present as a visible surface, not automatically a moral lesson. The frontal encounter remains on the scale of one person rather than becoming an emblem of a whole stage of life.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 421

16 / 20

Thalia

Michele Pannonio

1456–1457 · Museum of Fine Arts



Michele Pannonio. Thalia. Image credit: Michele Pannonio; Source credit: [1]. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The muse receives the elaborate setting of an enthroned figure. Ornament, fruit and smaller forms surround the central pink robe, making an abstract cultural role materially abundant. Michele Pannonio uses ceremonial presentation to give the personification authority. The narrow central body belongs to a larger furnished structure rather than standing alone with a simple attribute.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 44

17 / 20

Horse Frightened by a Storm

Eugène Delacroix

1824 · Museum of Fine Arts



Eugène Delacroix. Horse Frightened by a Storm. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Weather acts on the horse's balance. Raised forelegs, blown mane and turning body make fear visible across the whole animal rather than only in its eye. Delacroix's lightning and dark sky remain connected to that bodily response. The storm is therefore an immediate force within the subject, not atmospheric decoration added behind it.

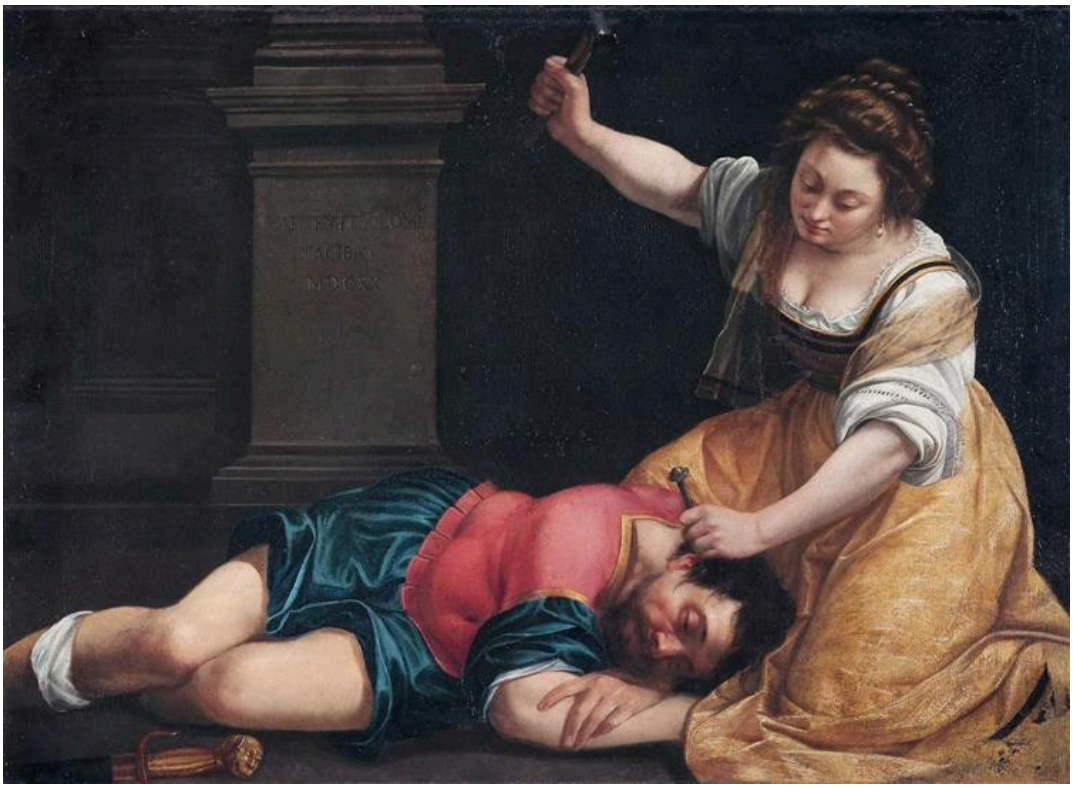
Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Jael and Sisera

Artemisia Gentileschi

1620 · Museum of Fine Arts



Artemisia Gentileschi. Jael and Sisera. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The raised hammer suspends the scene before the fatal blow. Artemisia Gentileschi makes Jael's coordinated hands oppose the extended, sleeping body in the foreground. Their unequal readiness gives the biblical episode its structure. The picture can be understood through the interval between preparation and action without turning it into an unsupported allegory of the painter's personal life.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Paris Interior

Mihály Munkácsy

1877 · Museum of Fine Arts



Mihály Munkácsy. Paris Interior. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Pictures, fabrics and polished objects surround the seated woman so densely that the room nearly competes with her as a subject. Munkácsy describes wealth as an environment, not a single expensive possession. The foreground dog adds another occupied level. The sitter belongs to an accumulated interior whose surfaces demand attention alongside her presence.

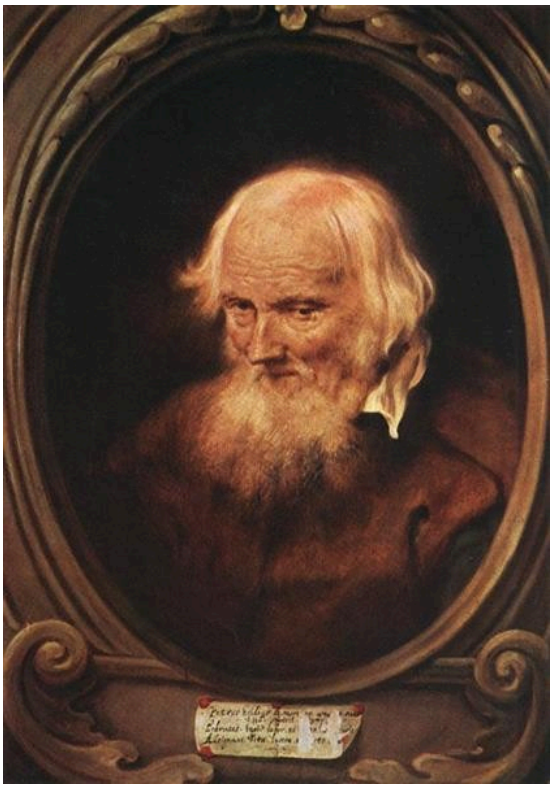
Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Portrait of Petrus Egidius de Morrion

Jan Lievens

1637 · Museum of Fine Arts



Jan Lievens. Portrait of Petrus Egidius de Morrion. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

An elaborate frame surrounds the dark oval, but warm light gives the forehead and white beard sufficient weight to hold attention. Lievens keeps the face particular inside a formal presentation. Ornament establishes the conditions of display; sharply differentiated features prevent the sitter from becoming merely the occasion for that display.

Object source · Open artwork

Begin with an action

Try reading a picture first through its hands: what is held, offered, supported or about to be done? Then add the title and historical context. The selection concerns recorded holdings; use the museum's current information to confirm what can be seen during a visit.

Further reading

A Treatise on Painting

Leonardo da Vinci; translated by John Francis Rigaud · Read free · English

Leonardo’s notes on painting examine gesture, expression and the organization of bodies. Read those passages beside Bruegel’s crowd or Artemisia’s paired figures, where a small change of position carries a large part of the story.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12
